

Session 5: Commissioning Moses

Key Takeaways

- Mount Horeb and Mount Sinai are two names for the same “mountain of God.”
- The burning bush is a rich symbol with many layers of literary and theological meaning.
- The identity of Yahweh doesn’t hang on the meaning of the name but on the demonstration of his character.

Horeb vs. Sinai

In [Exodus 3:1](#), Moses is tending flocks when he comes to “Horeb, the mountain of God.” Yet when the Israelites gather to worship God, the mountain is called Sinai. [Exodus 3:12](#) coordinates the two locations, demonstrating that these are two names for the same place. These names could reflect different sources, interchangeability, or a name change over time.

Horeb

Possible explanations for the use of the name Horeb include:

- The name of a wider area ([Exod. 17:1-7](#))
 - However, it is once called “Mount Horeb” ([Exod. 33:6](#))
- Wordplay with *hereb*, the word for “sword” ([Exod. 32:27](#))

Sinai

Possible explanations for the use of the name Sinai include:

- The whole desert (i.e., synecdoche, [Exod. 19:1](#))
- May be a new name for the mountain
- Wordplay with *seneh*-bush ([Exod. 3:2-3](#))

Literary Significance of the Burning Bush

God's concern for Israel frames Moses' encounter at the burning bush ([Exod. 2:23-35](#) and [3:6-10](#)). One image this literary frame creates is that of the bush representing Israel in the midst of fiery oppression in Egypt (cf. “iron furnace” in [Deut. 4:20](#); [1 Kgs. 8:51](#); [Jer. 11:3-4](#)). Though they are in the flames, they will not be consumed.

For more information, see Janzen, J. Gerald (2003). “And the Bush Was Not Consumed.” *Jewish Bible Quarterly*, 31. 219-25.



O'Keefe, Seraphim (2020). Mural for the Burning Bush Chapel of St. John of the Ladder in Greenville, South Carolina. [Orthodox Media](#).

In this mural by Seraphim O'Keefe for the Burning Bush Chapel of St. John of the Ladder, the Virgin Mary holds her hands in a prayer position that makes her like a chalice to receive Christ's flesh and blood. Moses' two encounters with God at Sinai, in which God revealed his name and his commands, frame the icon.

This icon reflects a centuries' old tradition of associating the burning bush with Mary (e.g., Gregory of Nyssa). She, too, had the glory of God within her, but it did not consume her.

For more information, see Davis, Ellen F. (2001). [Getting Involved with God: Rediscovering the Old Testament](#). Cowley. 45-49.

The Call of Moses

God calls Moses' name twice, "Moses, Moses," mirroring the call of Abraham, Jacob, and Samuel (see [Gen. 22:1-11](#), [31:11](#); [46:2](#); and [1 Sam. 3:4](#)). Moses' response, "Here I am," indicates his full availability and commitment to God.

The Name of God

God reveals his name to Moses in three statements.

- God said to Moses, "I will be whoever I will be ('ehyeh 'ăšer 'ehyeh)."
- And he said, "This is what you shall say to the Israelites, 'I will be' ('ehyeh) has sent me to you."
- And God spoke again to Moses, "This is what you shall say to the Israelites: 'YHWH (yahweh), the God of your fathers, the God of Abraham, God of Isaac, and God of Jacob has sent me to you.' This is my name in perpetuity, and this is how I am to be invoked from generation to generation."

These three statements create anticipation by gradually unveiling the personal name of God. God will flesh out the meaning of his name by acting on their behalf (see [Exod. 34:6-7](#)).

For more information, see Surls, Austin (2017). "Making Sense of the Divine Name in the Book of Exodus: Etymology to Literary Onomastics." *Bulletin for Biblical Research Supplement*, 17. Eisenbrauns.

Knowing YHWH's Name: Three Possibilities

Why does Moses ask God's name?

1. No one knew YHWH's name before this.
 - References to YHWH in Genesis could reflect a later perspective.
 - But 4:1 presumes that the name will be "verifiable" (see also Gen. 4:26).
2. Moses did not know YHWH's name. Pharaoh's daughter raised Moses, so this is possible.
3. Moses is confirming the divine identity. In a polytheistic context, Moses needed verification.

Moses' Objections and YHWH's Responses

- God responds to each of Moses' objections.
- Who am I? (Exod. 3:11) — I will be with you.
- Who are you? (Exod. 3:13) — I will be whoever I will be.
- What if they don't believe me? (Exod. 4:1) — What is this in your hand?
- I am clumsy-mouthed. (Exod. 4:10) — I will be with your mouth.
- Send someone else. (Exod. 4:13) — What about Aaron, your brother?

Reflection Question

Reflect on Moses' encounter with God at the burning bush. What do you notice that you had not seen before?